

SENATE RESOLUTION 245

By Akbari

A RESOLUTION to honor and commend Kortland Whalum of Memphis.

WHEREAS, Kortland Whalum is a powerful voice in American theater and soul music—a dynamic vocalist, actor, and educator whose artistic journey reflects deep Memphis roots, family legacy, and a lifelong commitment to storytelling through song. Known for his commanding stage presence and emotionally resonant performances, Kortland has become a fixture in Memphis's vibrant theatrical community while also emerging as a soul artist in his own right; and

WHEREAS, born into the legendary Whalum family, Kortland is the son of Rev. Kenneth Whalum Jr., the current pastor of Olivet Fellowship, and nephew of Grammy-winning saxophonist Kirk Whalum. Music was in the air from day one—his mother, Sheila, and grandmother were singers; his brothers Kenneth and Kameron are both renowned musicians. But rather than following the path of instrumental performance, Kortland found his voice—literally—as a singer. Initially wanting to emulate his brother Kenneth on the saxophone, he pivoted to vocal performance and discovered his calling; and

WHEREAS, his first performance at age six was in church—a setting that nurtured his confidence and sense of purpose. Over time, that foundation of gospel music, spiritual storytelling, and community shaped him into an emotionally intuitive performer. His trajectory shifted when he attended Overton High School, where exposure to Broadway productions during a trip to New York sparked a passion for theater. That passion followed him to Morehouse College, where he studied voice and deepened his appreciation for acting and performance; and

WHEREAS, Kortland's career blossomed in New York, but a role in Hattiloo Theatre's *The Wiz* brought him back to Memphis—where he's remained ever since, becoming a beloved figure in the city's performing arts scene. His standout performances in *Cats*, *The Wiz*, and *Raisin* have garnered critical acclaim for their emotional depth and nuanced storytelling. Chris Davis of the *Memphis Flyer* called his portrayal of Walter Lee Younger "as rich a performance as I've seen in ages"; and

WHEREAS, beyond the stage, Kortland served for four years as a vocal instructor at the Stax Music Academy, where he mentored students and led international performances. He currently serves on the board of the Memphis Listening Lab, further cementing his role as a community leader and cultural steward. In 2021, Kortland returned to his roots with *A Love Letter*, a deeply personal neo-soul EP featuring musical contributions from his entire family, including uncles and brothers. The title track—intimate, raw, and prayer-like—showcases Kortland's ability to convey vulnerability with finesse; and

WHEREAS, for Kortland, music is both mirror and medicine. "It really has been my therapy," he says. "I sing through happy times and through sad times. It's been like my twin throughout my life." Now nearing forty, he embraces the freedom of his artistry, always seeking the next opportunity to evolve, give back, and tell the stories that matter; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE SENATE OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, that we honor the service of Kortland Whalum, reflecting on his contributions to music and theater and his enduring legacy of excellence and service.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy.